

The Big Read **Demographics and population**

Why birth rates are falling everywhere all at once

Homes and phones are part of the reason for the demographic shift changing our world



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John Burn-Murdoch

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The demographic landslide defining our era is gaining speed — and terrain.

In more than two-thirds of the world's 195 countries, the average number of children born to each woman has fallen below the “replacement rate” of 2.1 that keeps populations stable without immigration. In 66 countries, the average is now closer to one than to two. In some, the most common number of children born to each woman is zero.

Both the pace and the breadth of the decline are defying expectations. Just five years ago the UN predicted there would be 350,000 births in South Korea in 2023. That was a 50 per cent overestimate: the real figure was 230,000.

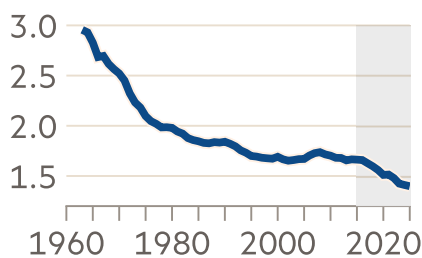
While high- and middle-income countries have been wrestling with demographic decline for more than half a century, the phenomenon has markedly accelerated in the past 10 years.

Analysis of data ranging from population records to Google searches indicates that although [many factors contribute](#) to falling birth rates, the most recent plunge appears connected with our use of technology.

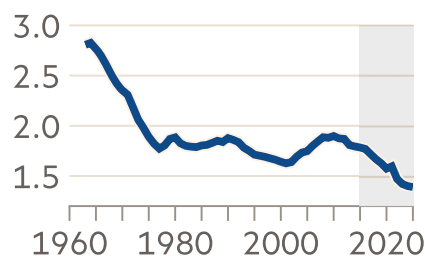
Birth rates have steeply declined in the past 15 years across different cultures and levels of economic development

Average number of children born per woman

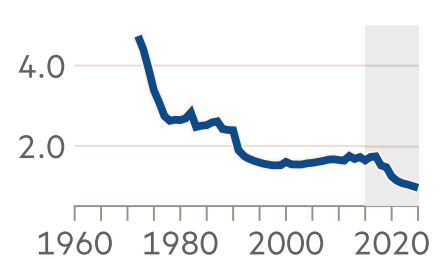
High-income countries



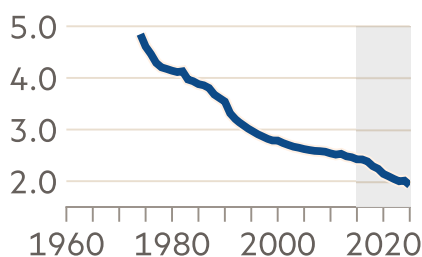
Northern Europe



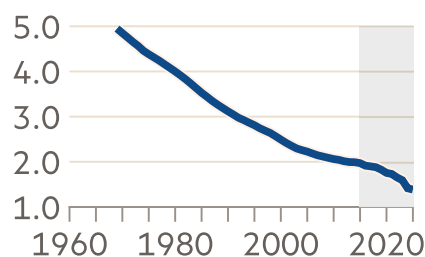
Eastern Asia



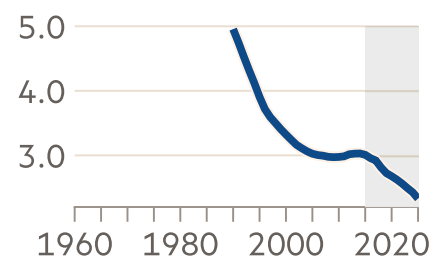
Middle-income countries



Latin America



Middle East & north Africa



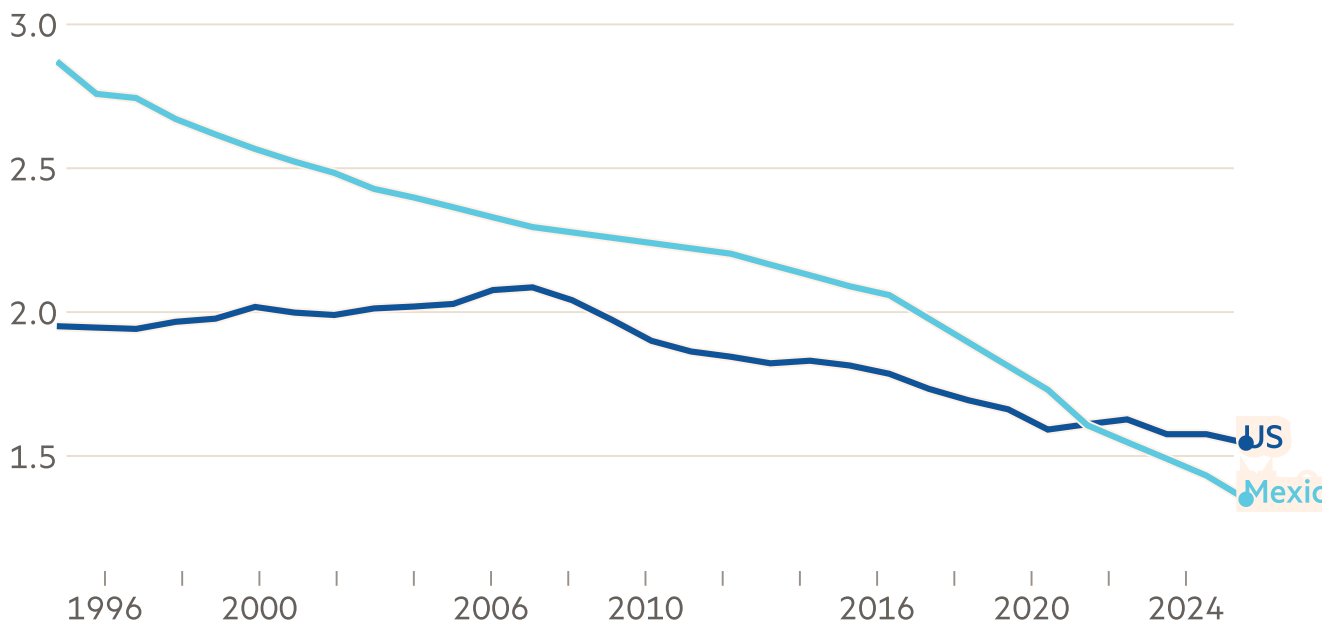
Sources: UN World Population Prospects; national statistics agencies; Birth Gauge
FT graphic: John Burn-Murdoch / @jburnmurdoch

Almost all of the world is now affected. Until recently, ultra-low and rapidly falling birth rates were primarily a concern for rich countries, but many developing countries now have lower fertility rates than much wealthier ones.

In 2023 Mexico's birth rate fell below that of the US for the first time — as, subsequently, did those of Brazil, Tunisia, Iran and Sri Lanka. Lower- and middle-income countries are now getting old before they get rich.

Mexico now has a lower birth rate than America

Average number of children born per woman



Sources: UN World Population Prospects; national statistics agencies; Birth Gauge

FT graphic: John Burn-Murdoch / @jburnmurdoch

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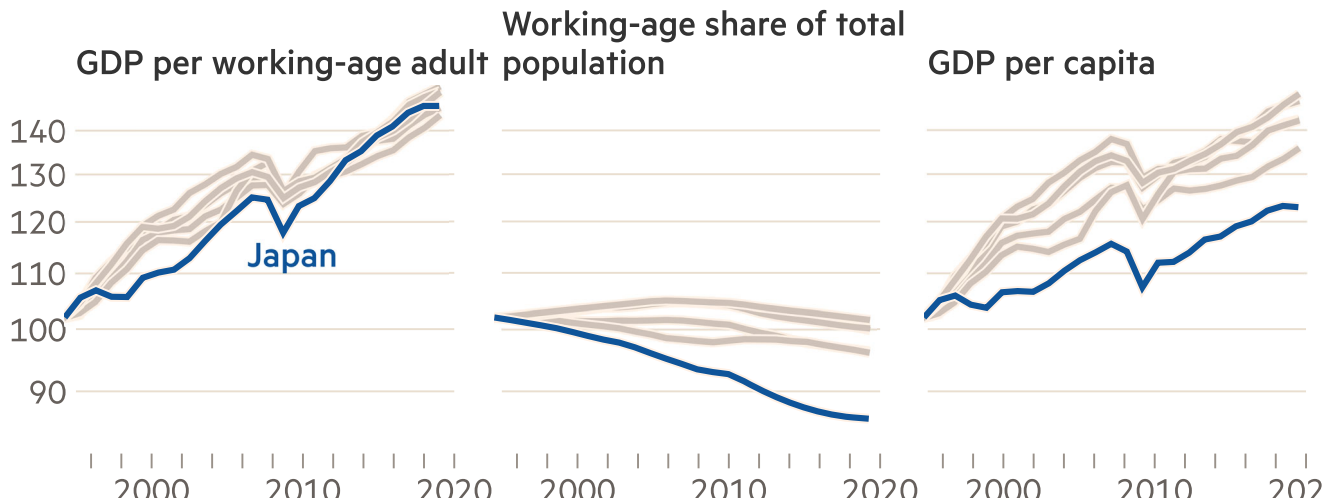
The defining problem of our time

Population ageing shrinks the workforce and [exerts a drag](#) on growth in productivity and living standards — Japan's stagnation since the 1990s is almost entirely [explained](#) by low birth rates that have shrunk its working-age population.

Fiscal pressure from ballooning spending on pensions and care also crowds out investment in infrastructure, helping create a sense of decline that [fuels anti-system politics](#).

Japan's working-age population is as productive as ever but shrinking, meaning less output to share out

Economic and demographic change in Japan and other developed countries (1995 = 100)



Sources: World Bank; UN; The Wealth of Working Nations (Fernández-Villaverde et al, 2024)

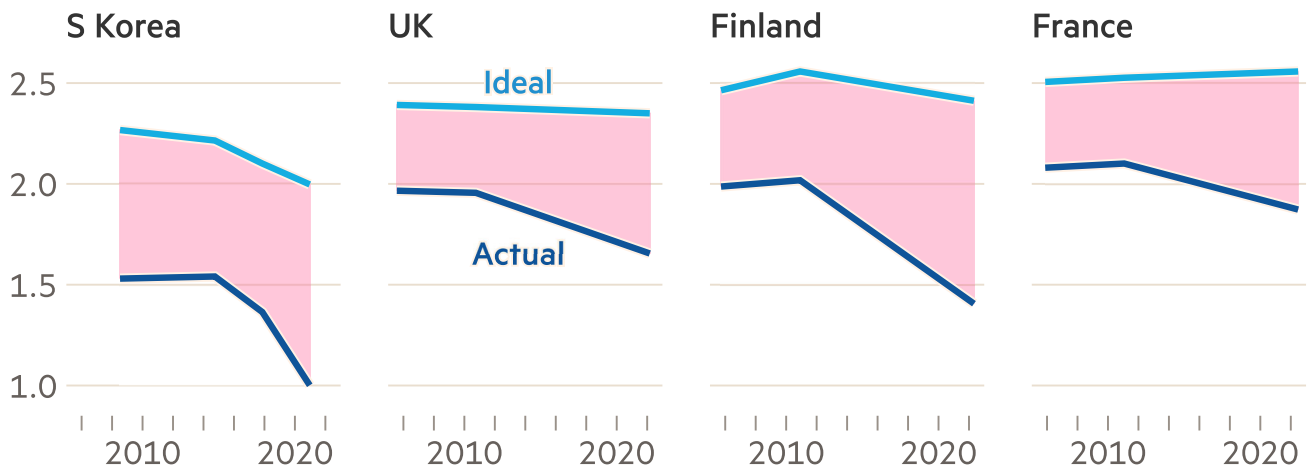
FT graphic: John Burn-Murdoch / @jburnmurdoch

“Fertility decline is the big question of our time,” says Jesús Fernández-Villaverde, economics professor at the University of Pennsylvania and a leading researcher on the [consequences](#) of demographic change. He argues that almost all pressing problems flow from the collapse in birth rates: “Everything else is downstream.”

One does not have to be Elon Musk, who argues that declining birth rates represent the “biggest risk to civilisation”, to see how they may already be exacerbating many of the world’s social and economic travails.

There is a widening gap between the number of children people would like and the number they have

Average ideal and actual number of children per woman



*'Actual' figures refer to tempo-adjusted total fertility rate

Sources: Eurobarometer; Gender and Generations Survey; S Korean National Fertility and Family Health and Welfare Surveys

FT graphic: John Burn-Murdoch / @jburnmurdoch

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Some hope a smaller population could help tackle climate change. But [a recent study](#) found lower birth rates will have at best a negligible impact on emissions over the coming decades.

Birth rates are often collapsing despite, not because of, people's desires. Most young men and women [still report wanting](#) around two children — even in South Korea where most women now have [zero](#).

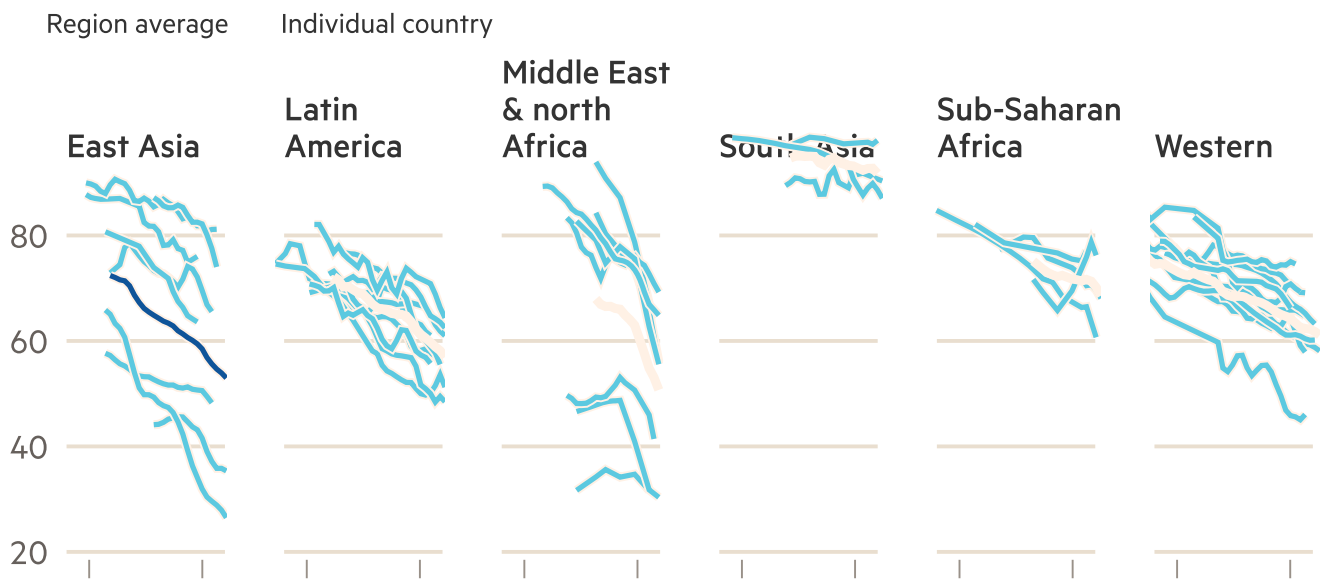
Instead, there is a “fertility gap” between goals and outcomes, due to frictions and frustrations that have much to do with modern lifestyles — including our homes and, increasingly, our phones.

Singles' night forever

In previous decades, the world's fertility rate went down because couples had fewer children. Now the main reason is that there are fewer couples.

Relationship rates among young adults are declining around the world

% of young adults (25-34) who are married or cohabiting



Source: FT analysis of data from the International Labour Organization, Arab Barometer, Demographic and Health Surveys and national statistics agencies

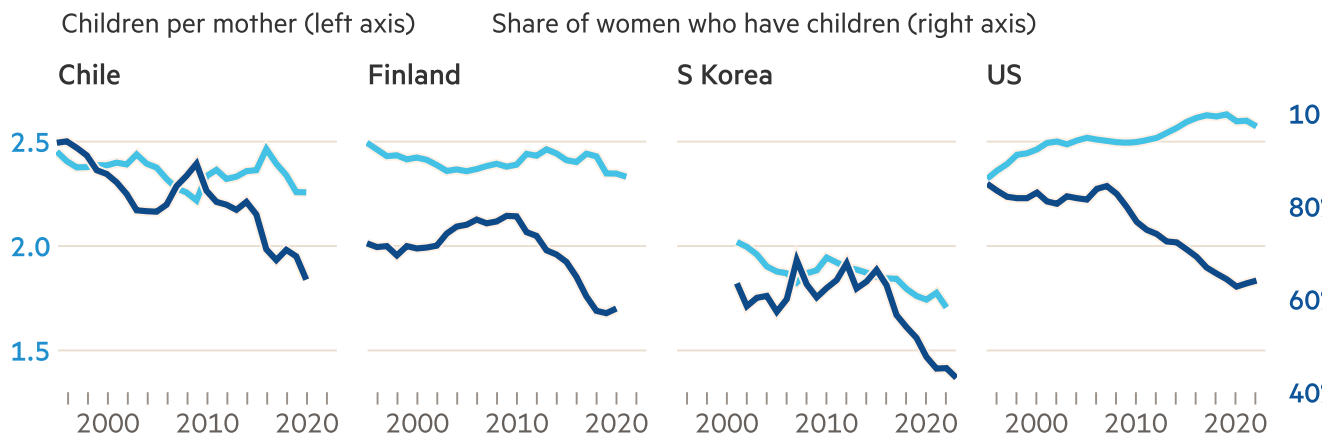
FT graphic: John Burn-Murdoch / @iburnmurdoch

Had US rates of marriage and cohabitation remained constant over the past decade, the country's total fertility rate would be [higher today](#) than it was 10 years ago.

A pioneering [study](#) by demographer Stephen Shaw shows that in the US and most high-income countries, the number of children that mothers give birth to is stable or even rising. But the proportion of women who have any children at all has fallen steeply in the past 15 years.

The number of children per mother has stabilised. But fewer women are becoming mothers

Number of children per mother and share of women who have children



Sources: Human Fertility Database; On a microdemographic framework for decomposing contemporary fertility dynamics (Shaw, 2025)

FT graphic: John Burn-Murdoch / @jburnmurdoch

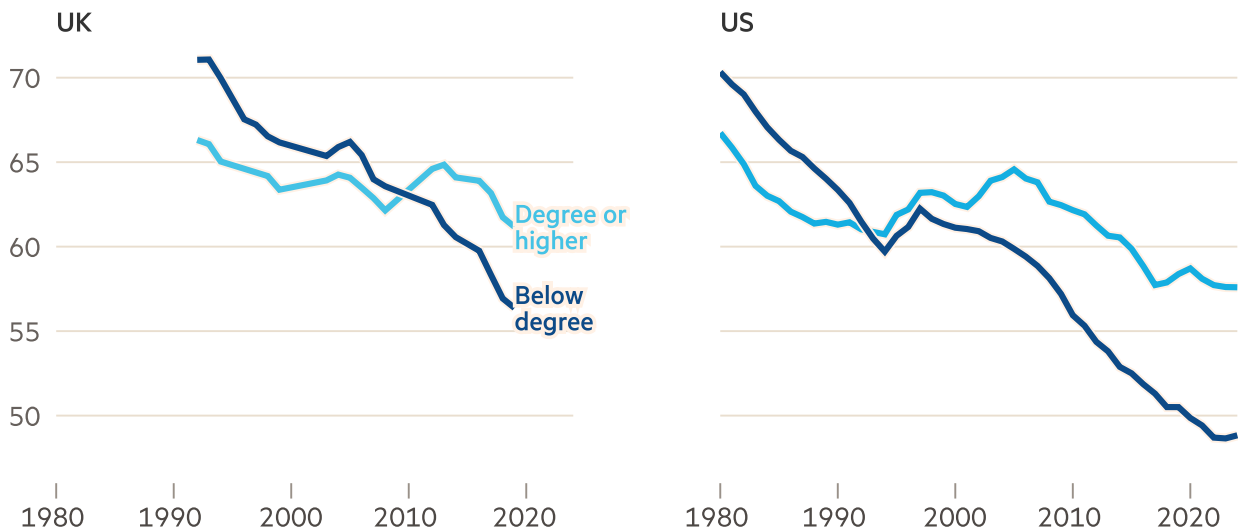
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The stereotypes often associated with this trend include women putting careers before children, or couples who choose not to have them despite plenty of disposable income.

But, across a wide range of countries, the decline in births and coupling is much steeper among those with the least education and lowest incomes. By contrast the share of university graduates forming couples and having children is stable or even [rising](#) in some cases. Family formation, it seems, has become [K-shaped](#).

The decline of long-term relationships has been steepest among people without a degree

% of 25- to 34-year-olds in couples, by education



Source: FT analysis of UK Household Longitudinal Study, UK Family Resources Survey and US Current Population Survey
FT graphic: John Burn-Murdoch / @jburnmurdoch
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Nor has state involvement by rich countries arrested the trend. Since the 1980s, developed countries have tripled real-terms per capita spending on child benefits, subsidised childcare and parental leave while the share of childcare [performed by fathers](#) has climbed steadily upwards. Birth rates have declined all the same — from 1.85 to 1.53 per woman.

Many people opt happily for a single life without children. But the data shows that across broader society, the number of people finding partners and having children is declining despite intentions. This is notably pronounced among the least well off, and accompanies mounting loneliness and [dating frustrations](#).

Home economics

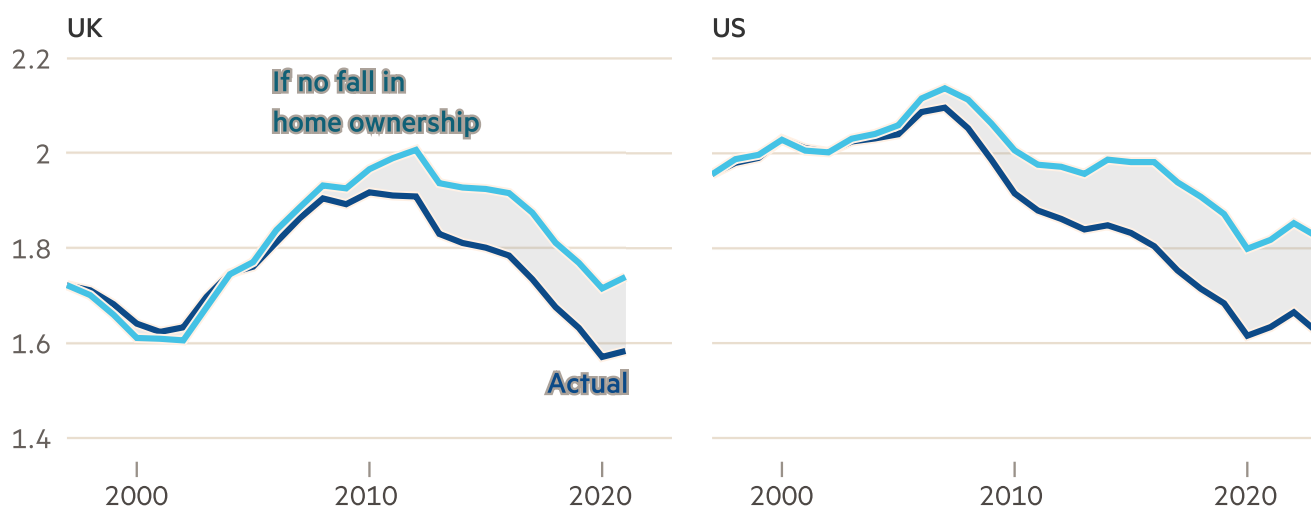
In several rich countries, including the US and UK, a major barrier to forming families in recent decades has been housing.

According to FT analysis, as much as half of those countries' decline in fertility rates since the 1990s can be explained by falling home ownership and a rise in young adults who live with their parents.

In such situations, the absence of long-term housing acts as a barrier to other long-term commitments.

Unaffordable housing explains some of the birth rate fall, but not the most recent drop

Total fertility rate: actual vs counterfactual where young adult home ownership rate is fixed at its 1997 level



Source: FT analysis of UK Household Longitudinal Study, UK Family Resources Survey and US Current Population Survey
FT graphic: John Burn-Murdoch / @jburnmurdoch
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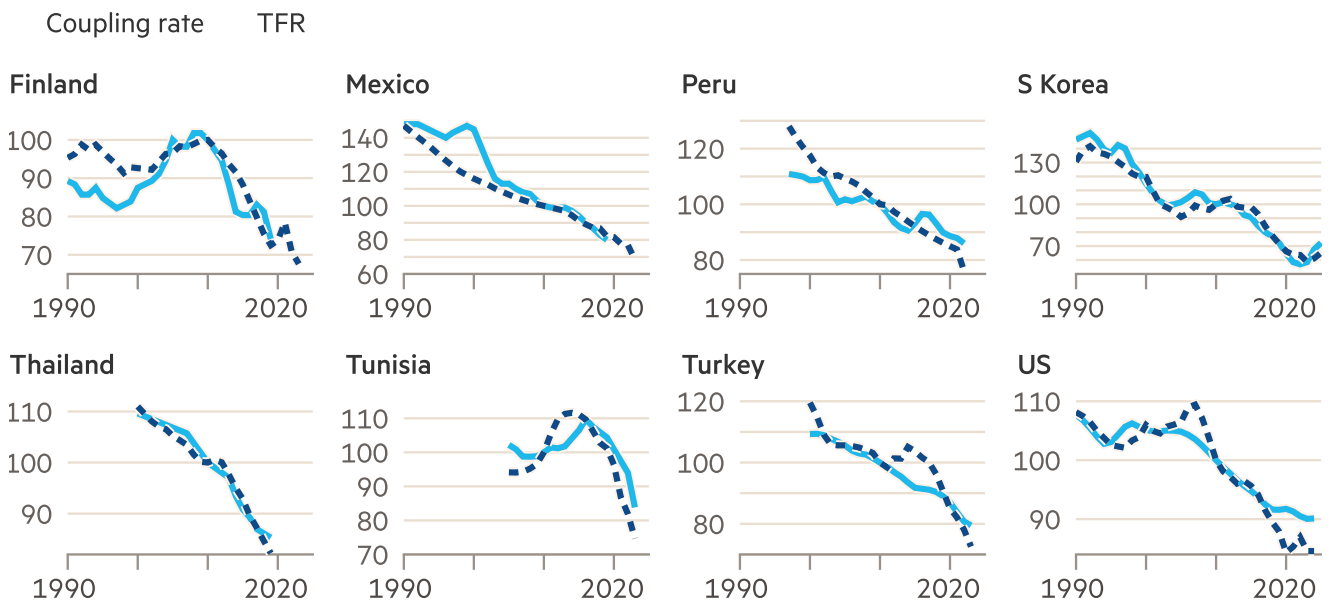
But this cannot account for the most recent steep decline or its global breadth.

In the Nordic region, for example, fertility has fallen despite economic stability and a rise in the number of young adults living on their own, rather than with parents or flatmates.

And even when couples can afford to move into their own place, they are increasingly likely to separate. In [several countries](#), people who move in together are now more likely to split up than to have a child, a sharp reversal of the historical norm.

Fewer couples mean fewer children

Relative change in coupling rate* and total fertility rate (2010=100)



*Coupling rate refers to either marriage or any co-residential relationship, depending on data availability

Sources: FT analysis of data from OECD, Our World in Data, Demographic and Health Surveys, Arab Barometer and national statistics agencies

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Other economic factors also fall short of being conclusive.

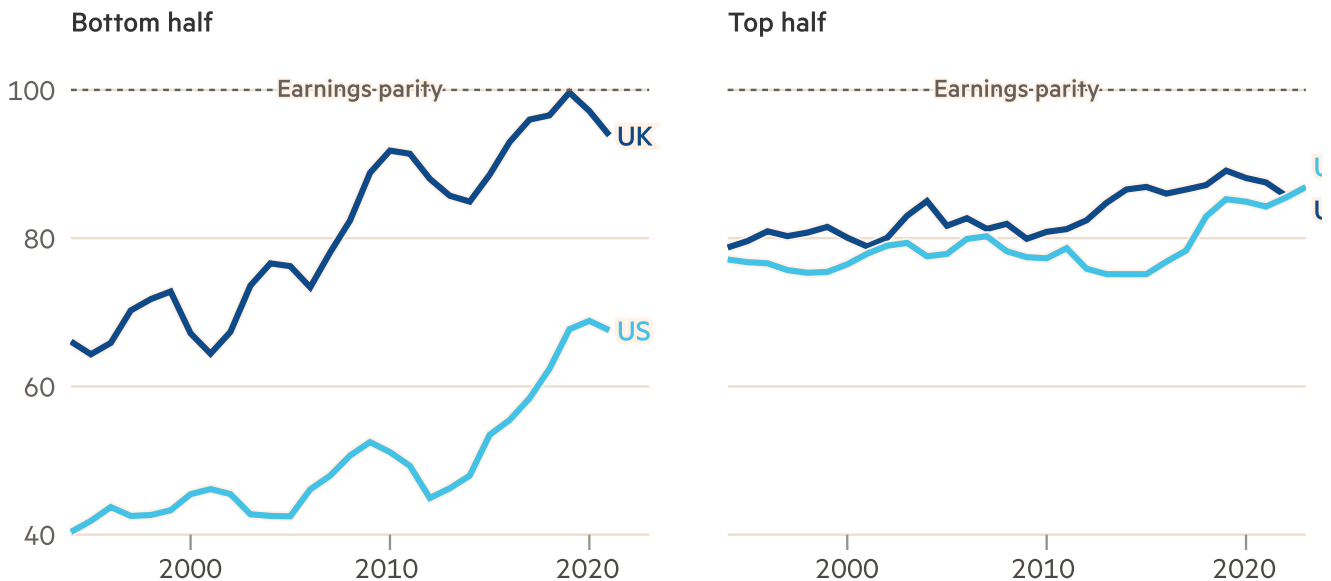
The recent demographic slide has occurred in countries hard hit by the global financial crisis as well as those virtually unscathed by it, and in both slow-growing western Europe and the rapidly-growing Middle East and south-east Asia.

Many point to young adults' economic precariousness. But while young people's earnings peak later than occurred during previous decades and their relative economic standing has [declined](#), these are gradual shifts that do not fit a sudden decline.

Another possible factor is the changing relative [positions](#) of young men and women. Girls are now far more likely to attend university than boys, and lower-educated young men are now often out-earned by their female counterparts, changing the calculus for settling down with someone. But these too are mostly slow shifts that apply much more to some parts of the world than others.

Young women in the bottom half of the income distribution are rapidly gaining on men

Women's average earnings as a % of men's among 24- to 28-year-olds



Source: FT analysis of UK Household Longitudinal Study and US Current Population Survey
FT graphic: John Burn-Murdoch / @jburnmurdoch
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The population threat in your pocket

Dissatisfied with purely economic explanations, researchers are beginning to point the finger at a new culprit — the digital devices and platforms that play an outsized role in young people's lives across the world.

Nathan Hudson and Hernan Moscoso-Boedo of the University of Cincinnati published a [paper](#) last month looking at birth rates through the lens of the rollout of 4G mobile networks in the US and UK.

The number of births fell first and fastest in the areas that received high-speed mobile connectivity earliest. The authors argue that smartphones have transformed how young people spend time with one another, sharply reducing in-person socialising and leading to the collapse in their fertility.

FT research indicates the same trend has affected other countries.

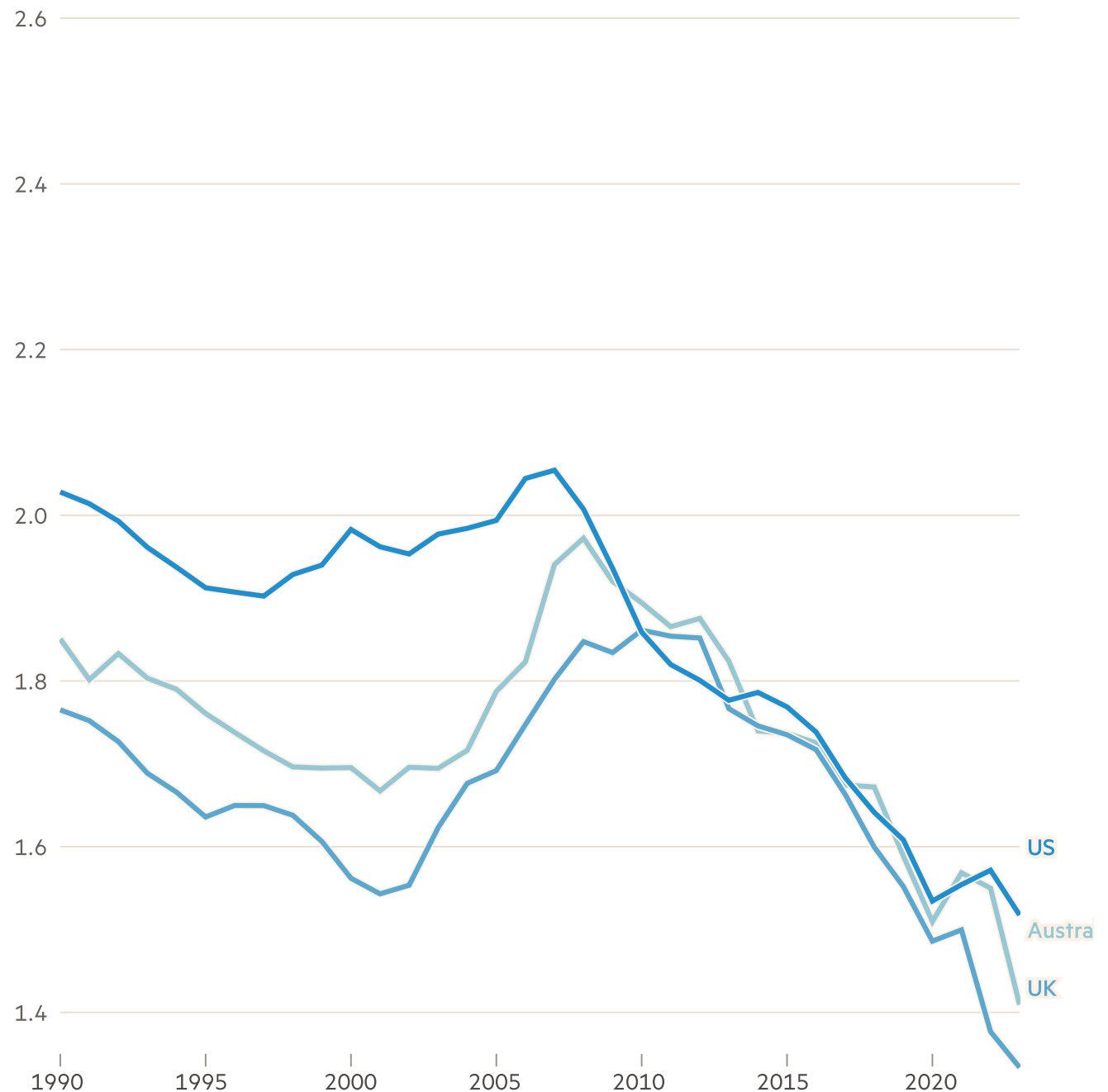
For example, US, British and Australian birth rates for teens and young adults were broadly flat during the early 2000s but began to fall markedly from 2007.

The same slide began in France and Poland around 2009, and in Mexico, Morocco and Indonesia around 2012. What had been steady declines in fertility in Ghana, Nigeria and Senegal became precipitous drops between 2013 and 2015.

All of these inflection points coincided with the mass adoption of smartphones in local markets — as measured by Google searches for mobile apps.

Could digital media be affecting birth rates?

Total fertility rate



Sources: UN World Population Prospects; national statistics agencies; Birth Gauge
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US, British and Australian birth rates were relatively stable during the early 2000s but began a marked decline from around 2007

The same slide began in **Mexico** and
Indonesia around 2012

In **Iran**, **Egypt** and **Senegal**, the decline
came around 2015

These look like disparate events, but if we shift them to align with the take-off of smartphones in each country...

...and adjust for what was happening to birth rates before phones arrived, we see a unified trend

In country after country the birth rate plunged after the introduction of smartphones, no matter what the previous trend was. The younger the age group, the more pronounced the downturn — a mirror image of smartphone usage patterns.

Melissa Kearney, professor of economics at the University of Notre Dame, says it is “quite plausible that the modern digital media environment has had profound effects on society that have led to a decline in romantic coupling”.

Indeed, Hudson and Moscoso-Boedo’s thesis that the key factor is less time spent socialising in person is supported by evidence from dozens of countries. In South Korea young adult in-person socialising has halved in 20 years.

Young people are socialising much less than in the past

Amount of time 15- to 29-year-olds spend socialising



Source: FT analysis of the American and Korean time use surveys, and the European Social Survey
FT graphic: John Burn-Murdoch / @jburnmurdoch
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“To meet a person you are going to marry requires filtering through a lot of people,” says demographer [Lyman Stone](#). “If you socialise much less, it takes you much longer to find a match if you find one at all.”

He adds: “If you spend lots of time socialising with your peers in the real world, your standards [for a potential partner] are anchored in the real world. If you spend your time on Instagram, your standards are anchored to an artificial sense of what is normal.”

Social media leaves its mark

Among couples, [sexual dysfunction](#) is higher for the young adults with the heaviest social media use, notes Finnish demographer [Anna Rotkirch](#).

She argues that the time taken up by social media — and the values and lifestyles such platforms project — has also made it harder for young adults to form committed relationships.

Stanford University’s Alice Evans adds that the more traditional a culture is in terms of its [gender](#) roles, the greater is the impact of smartphones on birth rates.

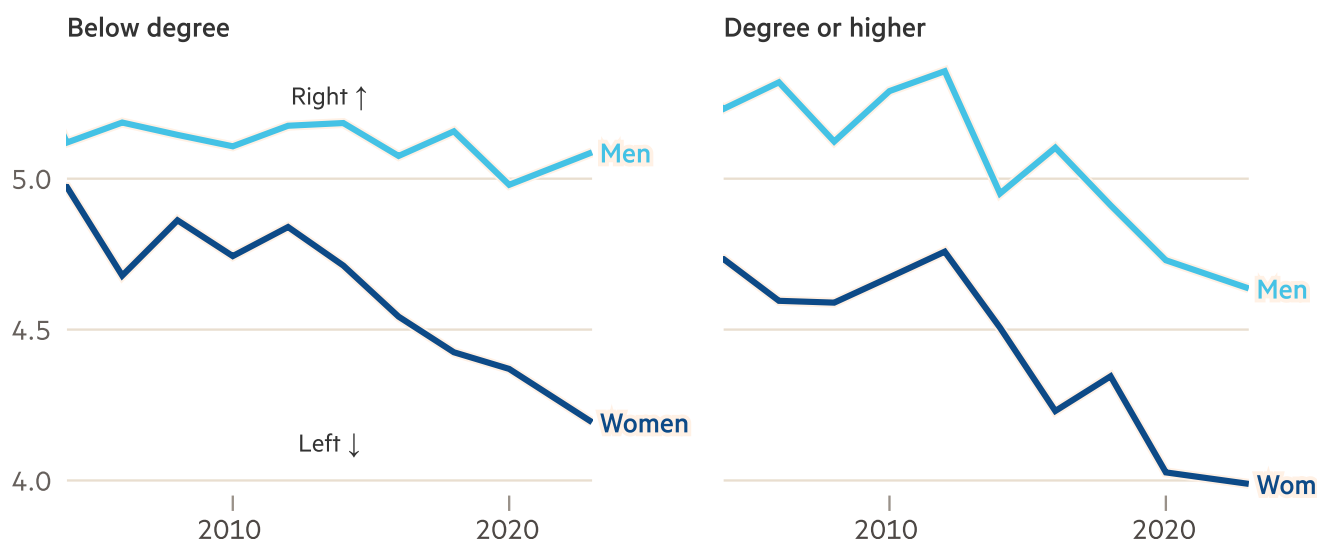
The data bears this out: the Middle East and Latin America show many of the steepest birth-rate falls of the past decade, and a [recent study](#) found that social media use is associated with lower fertility in Sub-Saharan Africa. In south Asia, where women’s web access is often more limited, fewer people remain single.

Evans describes what she calls “[cultural leapfrogging](#)”, adding that “Instagram and TikTok enable young women across the world to bypass traditional authorities . . . raising their expectations for a relationship in a way their male counterparts are often not prepared for”.

FT research has also indicated that the [emerging ideological divide](#) between young men and women is a smartphone-era phenomenon, concentrated among the non-college-educated. Among this cohort, women have moved leftward, men have not, and coupling and births have cratered.

An ideological divide has opened up between young men and women who didn't go to university

Average placement on left-right scale among under-30s, by education level (0=left wing, 10=right wing)



Source: FT analysis of European Social Survey
FT graphic: John Burn-Murdoch / @jburnmurdoch
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One possibility is that social media intensifies and consolidates people's reactions to trends such as housing difficulties or the changing economic positions of men and women, making decades-long processes feel like sudden waves, [amplifying](#) economic concerns, and creating a persistent sense of insecurity and worry that can act as a [prophylactic](#).

Indeed, theories about the impact of new media technologies on relationships and fertility are not new to the smartphone era.

In 2001, researchers Robert Hornik and Emile McAnany found that there was a stronger link between falling birth rates and [television ownership](#) than between income or education.

A decade later a study by Eliana La Ferrara and others found that watching TV soap operas that portray small families led women to have [fewer](#) children, and in 2018 Adrienne Lucas and Nicholas Wilson found that owning a television led couples to have [less sex](#).

Considering smartphone usage is heavier and more solitary than television viewing, the effects could be much larger.

Time for a solution

What should be done to contend with trends deeply embedded in modern lifestyles?

Governments have to resist the lure of unrealistic solutions — after all, there is no uninventing the smartphone. As Stone says: “If someone has bad eyes, we don’t fix their genes: we give them glasses.”

By contrast, there is [ample evidence](#) that providing secure and suitable homes to young couples increases their likelihood of starting a family.

“Baby bonuses” incentivising couples to have children are another option that may arrest the slide — but only if sufficiently [generous](#).

But government resources are limited, economic factors do not alone decide the demographic decline and incentives aimed at helping happy couples to have children may be beside the point when more and more people simply lack partners.

The bigger point is that falling birth rates appear to be part of a broader phenomenon of young adult singledom, [isolation](#) and deteriorating wellbeing. Given the likely link to technology and social media, the best hope of reversing the trend may be to change our digital habits — whether through [cultural shifts](#) or government regulation.

Even apart from our diminishing propensity to have children, the task of bringing together a fractured and frustrated generation is the challenge of our times.

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